

president and general manager at Red Hat's Platform business unit. Over a webcast, he said that, "While we are not at a place where we are making announcements ... our general target is the second half of 2013 to see RHEL 7 enter the marketplace."

While Red Hat is not revealing much about the date of the release, Totten said the OS will have improvements across its more than 2,000 packages, and that key focus areas are supporting new hardware, file systems, security and performance.

Android tablets closing in on Apple's iPad

If a recent survey by IDC is to be believed, Android-powered devices are gaining ground at a fast pace on the market-leading iPads. IDC has raised its 2013 forecast number to 172.4 million, up from 165.9 million and said that by 2016, worldwide shipments should reach 282.7 million.

"Tablets continue to captivate consumers, and as the market shifts toward smaller, more mobile screen sizes and lower price points, we expect demand to accelerate in the fourth quarter and beyond," said Tom Mainelli, research director, Tablets, IDC.

IDC's report stated that, "Android tablets are gaining traction in the market thanks to solid products from Google, Amazon, Samsung, and others. And Apple's November iPad mini launch, along with its surprise refresh of the full-sized iPad, positions the company well for a strong holiday season."

IDC now expects Android's worldwide tablet share to increase to 42.7 per cent for 2012 from 39.8 per cent in 2011. Apple's share is expected to slip to 53.8 per cent from 56.3 per cent in 2011.

"The breadth and depth of Android has taken full effect on the tablet market as it has for the smartphone space," said Ryan Reith, an IDC analyst.

"Android tablet shipments will certainly act as the catalyst for growth in the low-cost segment in emerging markets, given the platform's low barrier to entry on manufacturing. At the same time, top-tier companies like Samsung, Lenovo and Asus are all launching Android tablets that are similar to premium products, but are offered at much lower price points," IDC sources said.

Now, an open source alternative to Skype

Ubuntu users may know open source powered Ekiga as a default Voice-over-Internet Protocol (VoIP) client in that popular Linux distribution. But now it has made a comeback as an alternative to none other than Skype. Arriving some three years after the previous release, Ekiga 4.0—also known as 'The Victory Release'—is now available as a fresh new Skype alternative for users of Linux and Windows alike.

"This is a major release with many major improvements," wrote the software's developers in the recent announcement on the project's site.



Microsoft invites 'Android horror stories' from users!

As a strategy to promote its Windows Phone platform, Microsoft has asked users to narrate their 'Android horror stories'. If you have one that can impress Microsoft, the company will reward you with a Windows Phone for free!

It is not the first time Microsoft has resorted to such a strategy. Almost the same time last year, Microsoft launched a similar campaign—to make annoyed Android users switch over to Windows Phone. The company declared that it got around 3200 submissions from disgruntled Android users who had phones that were 'infected with malware'. Microsoft is playing on the same strategy again and this time it is using its Windows Phone Twitter account. The company has asked annoyed Android users to use the hashtag #DroidRage with their Android malware 'horror story'.

That's not all! Microsoft has also shared some tips with Android users suffering from malware infected devices. It has suggested the following:

- Wait for your Android phone to get infected with malware
- Recover from SMS scam bill shock
- Skip Steps 1 and 2; buy a Windows Phone and connect with people you care about instead of some hacker plotting in a dank basement

Will this strategy work again, particularly when Android has grown and Google is being extra-cautious about the malware factor? Let's wait and watch!